

COMPLICATIONS

1 Akasa's pilot strength now exceeds 770, but over 300 are grounded due to Boeing's delivery delays

2 Pilots on the bench receive only half the pay; the airline's strict training contracts (₹18–48 lakh per pilot) have drawn criticism

3 The CFO cites fuel costs, rupee depreciation, and one-time Boeing-related disruptions as reasons for increase in losses

4 However, he maintains that the path to profitability lies in disciplined cost management and fleet growth



Bhargava makes a relevant point. Whenever an airline closed down, starting with Kingfisher Airlines, Jet Airways, and GoAir, one company—IndiGo—captured their market share. “Therefore, the only option is to have a marketing strategy that starts eating into the market share of existing players,” he says.

The airline has also built a robust IT backbone, which helped it overcome the recent global Microsoft outage. “We made a conscious decision from day one to ensure that every process, from airports to our Operating Control Centre to commercial operations, is powered by the best technology available. The Microsoft Azure outage in July 2024 highlighted why

this matters: despite a global systems disruption, our operations continued with zero flight cancellations,” says Anand Srinivasan, co-founder and chief information officer of Akasa Air.

GLOBAL FOOTPRINT

Meanwhile, the airline is planning to expand its global footprint. It recently launched the Mumbai–Phuket route, which Praveen Iyer says is part of a long-term vision.

The airline is not overly worried about the resource-intensive nature of global operations and stiff competition. “While domestic aviation has experienced strong growth over the past six to seven years, international